

Ariel Churi

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EXPERIENCE

Razorfish

UX Director: 12/2021 - 05/2024

Managed a team of 4 UX/UI designers in a **SAFe/Agile** environment. Worked with business, product, and dev to ensure delivery of a **B2B** system for *Bridgestone/Firestone*. Developed and maintained the design process and implementation of the **Figma/Zeplin** design library and into integration into the *React* framework.

Wunderman/Thompson

UX Director: 02/2021 - 04/24

Workshopped with the client and their customers to determine stakeholder needs. Conducted **interviews**, **competitive analysis**, and **content audit** for a website redesign. Created **user-journeys** and **jobs-to-be-done** framework. Worked with the SEO and data analytics team to ensure business objectives were met.

Sotheby's

UX Lead: 11/2018 - 01/2021

I joined *Sotheby's* as part of their digital transformation initiative. I led UX designers and collaborated with multiple product owners to merge the digital and live auctions. My team brought together **client-facing**, online auctions with **point-of-sale** and administrative interfaces in a unified **design system**. Research included **observation**, **design-thinking** workshops, and interviews.

Unilever

UX Lead : 01/2018 - 11/2018

Supply-chain management moves from the sourcing of manufacturing ingredients to the store shelf. Unilever is exploring the use of **artificial intelligence** to manage this complex task. I interviewed people in the field and worked with the **AI/ML** scientists to uncover where real value could be added into this system. Through an iterative process, I developed wireframes and UI designs for a real-world, AI supply-chain management **dashboard**.

IBM

Product Development: 01/2017 - 01/2018

I worked closely with IBM's digital agency to create artifacts and experiences that included **touch interfaces** for editorial publishing and **mixed reality** experiences. I held **workshops** with IBM's top clients, **rapid prototyped** with cardboard and code, and created **motion graphics** to model interactions. I designed presentations to justify our work and get stakeholder buy-in.

Amazon/Comixology

UX Director: 06/2015 - 01/2018

Led a team of UX practitioners and creatives to implement a series of feature improvements to the subscription, purchase, and library management that positively effected **user-satisfaction**.

Successfully designed and implemented the user account and library merge program required by the company's aquisition by *Amazon*.

Other Clients

Havas Creative, MoMA, Samsung, Calvin Klein, Morgan Stanley, Ogilvy

ONGOING

Parsons, The New School for Design

Professor: 08/2014 - Present

Teaching and designing courses for undergraduate and graduate students.

- *Creative Computing / Web Design*: Introduce core concepts and design patterns of programming through front end web development.
- *Physical Computing*: Create and program embedded hardware systems. Design, prototype, and test a physical interfaces.
- *Design Research Methodology*: Introduce research and design methodologies. Apply the different techniques in a series of projects, engaging both users and experts.
- *Visual & Information Design*: Explore the fundamentals of visual communication and typography.

Sparkle Labs

Founder : 01/2011 - Present

- Ideation and development of educational electronics kits.
- 3D modeling and illustration.
- Instructional and package design.
- Sourcing, manufacturing, and factory visits.
- Consulting and prototyping of hardware and software applications for *Starcom Mediavest, Faith Popcorn, Kid Robot, Kill Screen, MoMA, Mattel, Hasbro*.
- Writing articles for *Make* magazine.

EDUCATION

- **MFA**: Interactive Telecommunications Program, New York University, NYC, 04/2004
- **BA**: Printmaking, University of the Arts, Philadelphia, 04/1996

RECOGNITION

- Guest Speaker on Design Thinking, *Eurobest Conference*, Lisbon, Portugal
- *Gallery Hanahou* solo show, New York, New York
- *The 2nd Art and Science International Exhibition and Symposium*, Beijing, China
- Contributor, *Make* magazine
- *Gwang Ju Design Biennale*, Gwang Ju, Korea
- *American Institute of Graphic Arts, Design Ranch* workshop
- *New Product Showcase, Compact-Impact/TKNY*, New York, NY
- *Ubiquitous Computing Conference*, Seattle, WA

SKILLS AND INTERESTS

- **16 years of art direction and UX design experience**, both agency and in-house. My work has included AR, in-store touch screen displays, service design, pitch decks, usability testing, personas, user journeys, information architecture, *accessibility, responsive design*, and design system creation and governance. I have been an IC, and I have led teams of designers, managing hiring, backlogs, design reviews, and personal crises. Software includes **Adobe Creative Suite** (Illustrator, Photoshop, InDesign), **Figma**, After Effects, and open-source alternatives such as Krita, Gimp, Inkscape, and Scribus. Some video work with streaming and green screens. I am continuously learning. At the moment, TouchDesigner and Unity.
- **Product leadership fundamentals** developed through cross-disciplinary work managing design and development projects from concept to delivery. My experience includes creating and maintaining project documentation, writing creative briefs and detailed specifications, user stories, and project requirements that bridge design, development, and stakeholder needs. I worked in strict **SCRUM**, including sprint planning and backlog management. Through my teaching experience, I have developed skills in stakeholder alignment, running discovery sessions, and translating complex technical concepts into accessible language for diverse audiences. My background in **design research** provides a foundation for user-centered product thinking, making clients a part of the process, and finding untapped value sources. Documentation practices span creating living specifications, maintaining project wikis, and developing clear communication artifacts that keep cross-functional teams aligned.

- **Design research methodologies** including tools for user research, system design, business design, brainstorming, and creative workshop facilitation. This includes human factors research, observation studies, design-thinking workshops, and user interviews that inform strategic decision-making.
- **Creating experiences with custom hardware** with Arduino, Raspberry Pi, and PicBasic Pro using JS, Python, BASIC, and even machine code. Also, electronic circuit design, PCB design, SMT soldering, LED arrays, sophisticated sensors, RF coms, WiFi, Bluetooth, household wiring, and complex peripheral ICs such as text-to-speech chips.
- My **fabrication skills** include casting and molding (silicone, plastics, and resins), weatherproof enclosures, sheet metal forming, carpentry (furniture and framing), refinishing, drywall installation, 3D printing, laser cutting, vacuum molding, interior and exterior house painting, creating mechanicals and specs, building a public display with a mechanical interface that must endure thousands of hours of heavy use, and building hoagies at the Wawa.
- An undergraduate degree in **print, printmaking**, and bookbinding has come in very handy when silk-screening on walls, engraving, etching, leatherworking, running an offset-lithography press, or working with printers on large-scale print runs, including specialty printing such as foil stamping, matte laminates with gloss varnish overlays, and temperature-reactive inks. I have worked with a number of photo processes, such as film photography, non-silver photography, and other light-sensitive materials. You can add painting, drawing, sculpting, matte cutting and framing, and art exhibit design and installation in there.
- In the **industrial design and manufacturing** column, there is AutoCAD, Blender, capturing 360° environments for HDR rendering, foam modeling, industrial plasticine modeling, packaging and cardboard engineering, working with manufacturers including factory visits in Shenzhen, part sourcing, BOMs, and working with shipping and logistics, creating commercial products including their branding, positioning, and creating the instructions, package design, and product photography. Small-scale, local manufacturing and creating assembly lines as well.
- I have been **teaching** a variety of courses at *Parsons, The New School for Design*, at the undergraduate and graduate levels. Course titles have included typography, interaction design, web design, data visualization, project management, and design research methodologies. I have created the curriculum, rubrics, and syllabi for many of these. I am now running a course I created called *Emergent Objects*, which combines hardware prototyping with UX design, and I am completing a certificate in future studies. Here is a link to my Teaching Statement. Additionally, I have taken a number of professional development workshops offered by the school, including *TESOL (Teaching English to Speakers of Other Languages)*, *Demystifying Active Learning*, *Anti-Oppression Workshop*, *It's a Generational Thing: Understanding Characteristics of Gen Z and the Implications for Teaching and Learning*, *XR and The Future of Immersive Learning*, *Immersive Storytelling with 360 Video and Virtual Reality*, *Digital Literacy and Ethics*, and *Teaching Students Today*.
- In the **information technology** space, I am comfortable setting up small-scale, multi-OS (Windows, macOS, Linux) local networks, ad-blocking DNS servers, local servers, remote servers, creating users, permissions, access controls, media servers, basic file-sharing systems, and automation. I enjoy exploring system configuration and troubleshooting as a learning exercise. Daily driver: *Arch Linux*.
- **Coding** is mostly frontend with JS, React, Tailwind, component libraries, a variety of frameworks, some backend with Python Flask, Git, regex, and bash scripting.
- I continue to integrate **AI** into my workflow, have completed an introductory ML course, experimented with deploying generative models locally, and I am working on an AI app myself.
- I obtained an *Advanced Open Water* certification and have logged nearly 50 hours SCUBA diving off the Long Island and Jersey coast.
- I am a *technician class* **HAM** radio operator, call sign KD2LPU.
- I recently completed a side quest into creative writing. I was commissioned to write a role-playing game adventure for Goodman Games. You can read it here: *The Fall of Al-Razi*.

That is a long list, but I have done most everything on it more than once.

Thank you.